Banerjee knows all too well what central interference can mean. Last year, the DoPT directed West Bengal chief secretary Alapan Bandyopadhyay to report to its office in Delhi hours after the chief minister allegedly skipped a review meeting on Cyclone Yaas with Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The 1987 batch IAS officer, who had never been on central deputation, was to superannuate on May 31. He is now fighting a case against the Centre.

The Centre's proposal has provoked other chief ministers too to join the chorus. Tamil Nadu's M.K. Stalin points out that it empowers the Centre to enlist any officer without the concurrence of the concerned state and place them "in perpetual fear of being penalised by the Union government at any time". Jharkhand's Hemant Soren argues it will create a fear psychosis in an IAS officer and adversely affect his "objectivity, performance and efficiency" and prevent him from offering candid opinion in matters that can be construed as "taking sides in sensitive matters of Centre-state disputes".

Yet others invoke the federal spirit to claim it is an attempt to undermine the states' authority. Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel warns that if implemented, it may lead to the collapse of the administrative system of states. He claims that as a result of the amendments, officers posted in various important capacities will be assailed by a sense of instability and ambiguity. "They will be in a dilemma while discharging their duties and due to political interference, it will not be possible for them to work impartially, particularly at the time of elections," says Baghel. The protests, of course, are largely from non-BJP-ruled states.

What the states find most galling is that while New Delhi seeks to consult the states on the number of officers to be deputed to the Centre, it wants overriding powers in case of any disagreement. With similar proposals for the IPS and IFoS, the states are apprehensive that this is an attempt to subvert their authority guaranteed by the Constitution.

THE LENGTH AND BREADTH OF THREE SERVICES

How IAS, IPS and IFoS officers are shared by the states and the Centre

IAS

TOTAL STRENGTH	5,231
POSTED AT THE CENTRE	458
POSTED IN STATE AND UT CADRE	4,773
IAS OFFICERS PROMOTED FROM STATE CIVIL SERVICES	1,316

IPS

TOTAL STRENGTH	3,049
PROMOTED FROM STATE CIVIL SERVICES	1,060
OFFICERS WHO CAN BE DEPUTED TO THE CENTRE	1,075

IFoS

TOTAL STRENGTH	2,224
PROMOTED FROM STATE CIVIL SERVICES	967
OFFICERS WHO CAN BE DEPUTED TO THE CENTRE	382

"THE GoI CANNOT RUN EFFECTIVELY WITH JUST 458 IAS OFFICERS SERVING IT. THE QUALITY OF GOVERNANCE, INDEED OF BOTH POLICY DESIGN AND EXECUTION, DEPENDS A LOT ON THE HAND AT THE WHEEL"

–SRIVATSA KRISHNA, *IAS*

OFFICERS' PLIGHT

The bureaucrats are in a quandary and, in private, fear the proposed changes expose them to reprisal. A major concern is the Union government arrogating to itself the authority to seek the services of any IAS officer for a central assignment. In effect, a bureaucrat perceived to be close to a rival party government can be brought to Delhi as a punitive measure.

But some do endorse the proposal. "Camaraderie and cooperation among the Union and the states cannot, like federalism, be a one-sided construct. It cuts both ways," argues Srivatsa Krishna, a 1994 batch IAS officer now on a sabbatical. "The Government of India (GoI) cannot run effectively with just 458 IAS officers serving it. The quality of governance, indeed of both policy design and execution, depends a lot on the hand at the wheel." He says any state treating AIS officers as officers of the state are flouting existing norms. Further, he asks, should the GoI not have the option of selecting specific officers for special situations, especially now when they are even bringing in professionals from the private sector?

Many, however, remain wary of the Centre's intentions. "India is a Union of states and that is how we have a central government. What is being attempted is to convert an All India Service as one under a centralised authority," rues retired bureaucrat and author M.G. Devasahayam.

Others say the problem goes deeper and involves the essential subjugation of an already much co-opted civil service. "When the Centre itself is pushing for lateral entry, what is the need for calling unwilling officers on deputation?" asks Ajit Kumar Singh, a retired IAS officer of Rajasthan. "This move will demoralise IAS officers and the services will lose their sheen in course of time. Short-sighted decisions can do long-